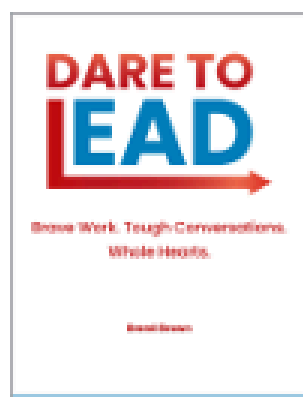




DARE TO LEAD

Brave Work. Tough Conversations.
Whole Hearts.

BRENÉ BROWN



The Big "So What"

To succeed in a complex and fluid world, organizations need brave leaders and courageous cultures. In this book, Brown presents the 4 courage-building skill sets that can be nurtured in any individual and organization.



Brave leadership and Courageous Cultures

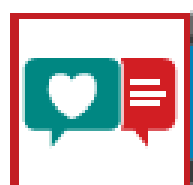


In any organization, the fear of failure and shame can lead people to hold back ideas, avoid risks and tough conversations. This stifles learning and creativity to hinder success in a world that demands continuous innovation.



Based on 2 decades of research and real-life experience, Brown found the antidote to fear and shame—brave leaders who are willing and able to face uncertainty and vulnerability head-on, and teach their teams to do the same.

- This book combines insights from Brown's previous books (including *The Gifts of Imperfection*, *Daring Greatly*, and *Rising Strong*) with her latest findings, to explain how you can become a daring leader. Specifically, there are 4 courage-building skills that can be learned and taught.



Skill #1: Rumbling with Vulnerability



To build courage, you must first learn to face your vulnerability.

KEY QUOTES

"*Courage is a collection of four skill sets that can be taught, observed, and measured.*"

"*What stands in the way becomes the way.*"
—Marcus Aurelius

- Vulnerability is the feeling we get when we face uncertainty and the risk of emotional hurt. A rumble is a conversation where people allow themselves to be vulnerable so as to serve a higher mission and one another (instead of hiding behind masks and armor to protect themselves and their self-interests).
- “Rumbling with Vulnerability” is at the core of daring leadership. You can’t build an innovative culture without exposing yourself to risks and failures. So, it’s crucial to face your fears and discomfort.



What Vulnerability Is and Isn’t



Brown dispels 6 myths about vulnerability (expanded from the original 4 myths in the book *Daring Greatly*):

- Myth #1: Vulnerability = weakness. Vulnerability makes us anxious but it’s not a sign of weakness. It takes courage to face your vulnerabilities. Real courage is about showing up even if it puts you in a vulnerable position, e.g. admitting a mistake, trying for another child after a miscarriage.
- Myth #2: “I don’t do vulnerability.” Risks and uncertainty are unavoidable. When you pretend they don’t exist, it allows your fears to drive you unconsciously.
- Myth #3: “I can go it alone.” Human beings are social creatures. We’re biologically wired for connection and empathy, and you can’t build meaningful relationships without vulnerability.
- Myth #4: You can engineer away the uncertainty/discomfort. Unlike system vulnerability, you can’t avoid or eliminate relational vulnerability. You can only learn the skills to manage it.
- Myth #5: Trust must come before vulnerability. Trust isn’t built from big heroic acts, but small daily exchanges, e.g. paying attention to small things about each other, or showing genuine concern. Trust and vulnerability go hand-in-hand and can’t be separated.

KEY QUOTES

“You can’t get to courage without rumbling with vulnerability. Embrace the suck.”

“The courage to be vulnerable is not about winning or losing, it’s about the courage to show up when you can’t predict or control the outcome.”

“You can do vulnerability, or it can do you.”

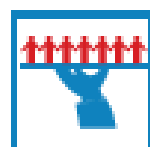
“We need to trust to be vulnerable, and we need to be vulnerable in order to build trust.”

- Myth #6: Vulnerability = disclosure. Vulnerability is not the same as emotional purging or disclosing sensitive information. To rumble with vulnerability, you need to set boundaries and create psychological safety: acknowledge that problems/uncertainties exist, talk openly about the emotions surrounding those risks, listen to people's questions/concerns, and create a safe space for people to work through the issues.



The Square Squad. We need feedback to grow. Yet, we shouldn't worry about every single criticism we get. The key is to get solicit feedback only from people who truly matter, and let go of the rest.

- On a small piece of paper (1x1 inch), list down the handful of people whose opinions truly matter. These should be people who love you as you are (including your vulnerabilities and imperfections), and are able/willing to rumble with you.
- Keep this list (your square squad) with you. Take 10 mins to let them know you're grateful that they care enough to be authentic and honest with you.



Have the Courage to Serve



To serve their people, leaders must have the courage to address uncomfortable issues. In her first year of command at the Air Force, Colonel Dede Halfhill was asked a tough question—whether the pace of operations could be slowed down because the airmen were feeling tired. She knew that the real issue wasn't about physical fatigue, so she took the opportunity to share about a study that found exhaustion to be a manifestation of high levels of loneliness. This opened an honest discussion about loneliness in the Air Force and how she could best support the airmen.

- Joseph Campbell says, "The cave you fear to enter holds the treasure you seek." To get to your treasure (e.g. become a courageous leader, feeling connected, work toward exciting goals), you must confront the fears that stand in your way (e.g. fears of making bad decisions, being alone, or getting stuck).

KEY QUOTES

"Daring leadership is ultimately about serving other people, not ourselves. That's why we choose courage."

*"The cave you fear to enter holds the treasure you seek."
—Joseph Campbell*

 One of the hardest things for leaders is to deal with difficult conversations (e.g. giving and receiving feedback, addressing bad behaviors or poor performance) which stir up fear, uncertainty and vulnerability.

- *It's kind to be clear and unkind to be unclear.* When you avoid difficult conversations or tell people half-truths, you're actually doing them a disservice. It's also unfair for you to hold someone accountable if you didn't set clear expectations in the first place.
- Your team members may also find it hard to bring up issues or to articulate their feelings and concerns. If you find yourself dealing with the same problematic behaviors repeatedly, it's a sign that you must dig deeper to uncover the underlying issues. Be patient—it may take multiple attempts before people are ready to share/talk.

 Here are several tools you can use to have an open conversation and rumble with vulnerability:

- Build a safe container to hold your conversations. Ask your team members: "What do you need to show up and do the work?", "What will get in the way of you showing up and doing the work?" and "What does support from me/us look like?"
- Use permission slips to explicitly give yourself permission to feel or do something difficult (e.g. to give/receive clear feedback, stay open-minded, or ask for help). You can also apply this as a team, e.g. at the start of a meeting, go round the room and have everyone share their permission slips.
- Resist the instinct to defend your views. Be curious about where the other person is coming from:
 - (i) Ask for clarification/elaboration with phrases like "Say more" or "Tell me more."
 - (ii) Make sure you actually listen. Stop talking and don't interrupt, even during pauses in the conversation.
- Allow people to express and own their feelings, but set clear boundaries if their behaviors are unacceptable. For example, "I know this is a difficult conversation and we're

KEY QUOTES

"Clear is kind. Unclear is unkind."

"Leaders must either invest a reasonable amount of time attending to fears and feelings, or squander an unreasonable amount of time trying to manage ineffective and unproductive behavior."

both tired. It's ok to be angry, but it's not ok to shout and throw things."

- Call for a time-out if the rumble becomes unproductive, or if you need the time/space to think things through. For example, you can say, "I need some time to think about what I've heard. Can we take a lunch break and circle back in 2 hours?"
- Have the courage to share your thoughts/feelings. For example, Colonel Halfhill admitted that she was heartbroken to realize so many airmen were feeling lonely, and she was afraid because she didn't really know what to do. This made it easier for the airmen to open up and find solutions as a team.



Shifting from Armored Leadership to Brave Leadership

 Often, leaders try to keep emotions away from the workplace, thinking that it'll make them more efficient. In reality, the opposite is true—when you lock away your heart/feelings, you also lock away the gifts of empathy and emotional literacy. This leads to disconnectedness from yourself and others, to reduce curiosity, engagement, courage and performance.

- Wholeheartedness is about knowing that you're whole and worthy of love/belonging despite your imperfections. Instead of trying to hide your feelings to protect yourself, wholeheartedness is about *integrating* your thoughts, feelings and actions. It's about embracing *all* aspects of yourself—both the good and the bad—that jointly make you who you are.

 Specifically, Brown's research uncovered 16 types of armor that people wear at the workplace to protect themselves from the fear of failure, being judged, misunderstood or shamed.

- Learn to remove your armor and move from armored leadership to daring leadership:

KEY QUOTES

"The problem is that when we imprison the heart, we kill courage."

From Armored Leadership...	...to Daring Leadership
Perfectionism: Focus on appearing perfect to avoid shame, blame, or judgment.	Focus on how to improve (with empathy, compassion and healthy struggles).
Foreboding joy: Avoid celebrating or rejoicing to avoid disappointed.	Practice gratitude and celebrate milestones and victories.
Numbing: Bury yourself in activities to drown out negative feelings (but end up numbing the positive emotions too).	Confront the underlying feelings. Find ways to gain real comfort and renew your spirits.
Winner-vs-Loser mentality: Adopt a binary view and avoid vulnerability.	Embrace/integrate paradoxes (e.g. fierce and kind, scared and brave).
Pretend to be a know-it-all or insist on being right.	Focus on getting things right instead of being right.
Hide behind cynicism/sarcasm.	Say what you mean. Clearly express the goal, how to get there, and your belief in others.
Use criticism to deflect attention, avoid change or responsibility.	Focus on (and reward) contribution, not criticisms.
Exploit power over others for self-interests.	Use power to effect change for a wider purpose.
Hustling blindly (jump from 1 area to another or blow your own trumpet) to prove your worth.	Rumble with people: help them to leverage their unique strengths/ contributions and collaborate.
Lead with compliance and control: micro-manage and create the self-fulfilling prophecy that people can't succeed without tight supervision.	Explain the reason behind strategies, priorities and tasks. Use TASC: clarify who owns the Task, give Authority with accountability, give people the time, resources and clarity to Succeed, and have a Checklist of what "done" looks like.
Peg self-worth to productivity: Use work hours to measure value.	Recognize the value of play, rest and recovery for creativity and social-emotional skills.
Tolerate a "fitting-in" culture where people must suppress their true selves to be accepted.	Build inclusive cultures that tap on diverse views/strengths and foster authenticity.
Play up uncertainty and fear to gain control/power	Create a safe space for people to rumble, validate facts and manage uncertainties
Focus on personal credit and accolades at the expense of the team.	Focus on helping others to develop, shine and be rewarded.
Zigzagging: Waste time and energy by avoiding fear/conflict/discomfort.	Address your own fears/pain, blind spots and unproductive behaviors, and help others to do the same.
Lead from hurt: Take out fears and frustrations on others.	Confront your vulnerability, talk straight and take concrete action.

- Of the defensive behaviors above, the first 3—*perfectionism, foreboding joy, and numbing*—are the most common.

KEY QUOTES

"The people who count are the people who are putting themselves out there and making contributions, cheap seats be damned."

"Once everyone understands their value, we stop hustling for worthiness and lean into our gifts."

*"The opposite of play is not work—the opposite of play is depression."
—Stuart Brown*

"True belonging doesn't require you to change who you are; it requires you to be who you are."

"It's time to lift up our teams and help them shine."

"Daring leadership is leading from heart, not hurt."

(i) *Perfectionism* is the desire to appear perfect to protect yourself from the feelings of shame, blame, or judgment. It's not about excellence because you're focused on others' opinion instead of your own improvement. In the quest for perfection, you avoid risks and mistakes to block learning and innovation. Since perfection doesn't exist, you're basically setting yourself up for failure, which further reinforces your sense of inadequacy to form a vicious cycle.

→ Brave leaders counter this by encouraging empathy, compassion and healthy struggles. They focus on ways to improve instead of what others think of them.

(ii) *Foreboding joy*: When something joyful happens, we dare not celebrate or rejoice because we think it's too good to be true and we're afraid to get hurt/disappointed.

→ Brave leaders celebrate milestones and victories. They practice gratitude, e.g. keep a gratitude journal, or start/end each meeting with team members sharing what they're grateful for.

(iii) *Numbing*: We tend to numb negative feelings by burying ourselves in certain activities (e.g. eating, drinking, working, shopping). Unfortunately, when you numb your negative emotions (e.g. anxiety and resentment), you'll also numb your positive emotions (e.g. joy and love).

→ Brave leaders (i) watch out for numbing behaviors, (ii) honestly confront the reasons for the underlying feelings, and (iii) find ways to gain true comfort and renew their spirits (instead of numbing themselves).



Shame and Empathy



Shame is the feeling that we're not "good enough". It's the sense that we're flawed and unworthy of love, belonging, and connection. It can surface any time, e.g. when you're caught lying or when someone calls you a loser.

- There are 3 truths about shame. Shame is *universal*, i.e. everyone experiences it. We're all *uncomfortable* to talk

KEY QUOTES

"Perfectionism is not a way to avoid shame. Perfectionism is a function of shame."

"We cannot selectively numb emotion. If we numb the dark, we numb the light."

"Shame is universal and one of the most primitive human emotions that we experience."

about it. Yet, the more we *avoid* it, the more power it has over us.

- Shame is often confused with guilt, embarrassment and humiliation.
 - (i) You feel *guilty* when you do something bad, whereas you feel shame when you think you're a bad person. Guilt can motivate change, while shame can be debilitating.
 - (ii) You feel *humiliated* when you don't believe you deserve a bad outcome, whereas shame fills you with self-reproach.
 - (iii) *Embarrassment* is more fleeting. We know that others have had similar experiences, and it doesn't define who we are.
- At the workplace, shame manifests in the form of perfectionism, gossip, back-stabbing, comparison, favoritism, discrimination, blame, bullying, etc. When these are used as management tools, or when bad deeds are explicitly covered up, it's a sign that shame has become pervasive in a culture.



Empathy is the opposite of shame. It's also the best antidote to shame.

- Empathy is *not* about offering sympathy, advice or trying to fix things. It's about connecting with someone's feelings, and letting them know that we're with them in their pain. Even if you haven't experienced something, you can still empathize with the underlying emotions behind the experience.
- You can express empathy with phrases like, "Me too", "I understand how you feel", or "Oh man, I feel you." It takes courage to be with someone in their darkness so they don't feel alone. However, it's important to maintain boundaries, i.e. don't take on their struggles or emotions until you get stuck with them.
- Empathy involves 5 skills:
 - (i) Skill #1: *Taking their perspective*. We can never truly see things through someone's eyes since we all have

KEY QUOTES

"The discomfort of cognitive dissonance is what drives meaningful change. Shame, however, corrodes the very part of us that believes we can change and do better."

"Empathy is not connecting to an experience, it's connecting to the emotions that underpin an experience."

"Empathy isn't about fixing, it's the brave choice to be with someone in their darkness."

"Perspective taking requires becoming the learner, not the knower."

different backgrounds and life experiences. However, we can seek to understand them as far as possible, and respect that their perspectives are true even if they differ from ours.

- (ii) Skill #2: *Don't judge*. We tend to be the most judgmental in areas where we are the most vulnerable to shame.
- (iii) Skills #3 and #4: *Understanding their feelings and articulating that you understand*. However, you can't empathize with others' feelings if you can't even recognize your own. You first need the emotional literacy to process and talk about your own feelings.
- (iv) Skill #5: *Be mindful* to relate to those emotions without suppressing or exaggerating them.
- Beware of 6 barriers that block empathy:
 - (i) Expressing sympathy, i.e. feeling bad *for* them ("Oh, you poor thing"), instead of feeling bad *with* them ("I feel your pain. I'm with you.")
 - (ii) Negative reaction, e.g. "Gosh, I'd just die if I were you."
 - (iii) Expressing disappointment, e.g. "I can't believe you'd make such a mistake."
 - (iv) Judging or blaming, e.g. "How could you let that happen?" or "It's all his fault. We should make him pay!"
 - (v) Glossing over it, e.g. "Don't worry, I'm sure it's nothing."
 - (vi) One-up comparison, e.g. "If you think that's bad, wait till you hear what I went through."
- One of the biggest barriers to empathy is the lack of self-compassion. Resist the urge to punish or shame yourself when you stumble. Treat yourself like how you'd treat someone you love.

 Build shame resilience by shifting from shame to empathy. This means responding to shame with authenticity and clear values, so you emerge with even more courage, compassion, and connection.

KEY QUOTES

"It's almost impossible to process emotion when we can't identify, name, and talk about our experiences."

"Empathy is feeling with people. Sympathy is feeling for them."

"Empathy is infinite and renewable. The more you give, the more we all have."

- Understand and recognize shame and its triggers. That way, you're less likely to default to shame shields like (i) moving away (withdrawals, silence), (ii) moving toward (trying to please/appease others) or (iii) moving against (being aggressive, fighting shame with shame).
- Be aware. When we feel shame, we zoom in on our flaws and bad feelings as if there's something uniquely wrong with us. Learn to zoom out and see the fuller picture, including how our feelings are exaggerated by social influences and expectations.
- Reach out. Connect with others so you're reminded that shame is universal and you're not alone.
- Speak shame. Once you find the courage to talk about shame, it loses its power over you.



Curiosity and Grounded Confidence

 Rumbling with vulnerability isn't easy. You will inevitably stumble, fail, and must constantly adjust your approach as you unlearn and relearn. However, if you stay curious and keep practicing, you'll gradually build grounded confidence to (i) uphold your values, and (ii) respond with self-awareness instead lashing out defensively.

Grounded Confidence = Rumble Skills + Curiosity + Practice

- We don't know what we don't know. To get curious about something, you must first have *some* awareness of it. Here are some useful rumble-starters to practice curiosity:
 - Tell me more.
 - The story I'm making up is...
 - I'm curious about...
 - I'm wondering...
 - Help me understand...

KEY QUOTES

"Shame resilience is about moving from shame to empathy—the real antidote to shame."

"Find the courage to share our experiences and the compassion to hear others tell their stories, we force shame out of hiding and end the silence."

"We can't be curious about something we are unaware of or know nothing about."



Skill #2: Living into your Values



Often, our values drive us to do what's courageous or uncomfortable, and to pursue our beliefs even when we're surrounded by critics and cynics. "Living into your values" means to practice what you preach, i.e. to do what you believe to be the most important. This in turn requires that you (i) get clear about your values and (ii) think and act in alignment with those beliefs.

- Name your values. All of us have a set of core values that define who we are. These values apply in *all* aspects of our work and personal lives. Download the list of values from the Dare to Lead website, and choose just 1-2 values that are the most crucial to you. These values should meet 3 criteria: They (i) define you, (ii) reflect who you are at your best, and (iii) can guide you in hard decisions.
- Define key supporting behaviors for each core value. Consider: (i) 3 behaviors that support each value, (ii) 3 behaviors (which you're tempted to do) that contradict the value, and (iii) an example of a time when you were fully living into the value.
- When you're surrounded by shame, scarcity, and criticism, focus 2 things: empathy and self-compassion.
 - (i) Empathy: Think of 1-2 people who know and support your values, and what support from them looks like.
 - (ii) Self-compassion: Support yourself the way you would someone you love.



Likewise, you can "operationalize" values in organizations by identifying the observable and learnable behaviors that'd allow team members to live into their shared values.



It's especially hard to stick to our values when we're giving and receiving feedback.

- As a rule of thumb, you're ready to give feedback if you can:

KEY QUOTES

"Daring leaders who live into their values are never silent about hard things."

"If we can't cheer ourselves on, we shouldn't expect others to do it. If we don't make our values priorities, we can't ask others to do it for us."

"We don't fully see people until we know their values."

- (i) Sit next to the other person (not across from them) and put the problem in front of you (not between you).
 - (ii) Ask questions, listen, and accept you don't know everything.
 - (iii) Thank them for their effort and recognize their strength (not just criticize or pick at their mistakes).
 - (iv) Acknowledge your own role in the problem, and hold them accountable without shaming or blaming.
 - (v) Discuss how the challenges can bring growth/opportunity.
 - (vi) Model the openness and vulnerability that you expect from the other person.
- When you're receiving feedback, remind yourself to listen, stay open-minded, and act in accordance to your values. For example, you can use self-talk like: "I'm brave enough to listen", or "This is part of the path to mastery."



Skill #3: Braving Trust



Trust is vital for meaningful relationships and team cohesion. Yet, it's hard to talk about trust—we end up zig-zagging around it or talking in vague terms that lead nowhere. To rumble about trust, you need to get specific. Use the BRAVING Inventory to break it down into 7 specific behaviors that can be explicitly addressed.

- Boundaries: Respect others' boundaries. Be willing to ask what's ok or not ok, and to say "no".
- Reliability: Do what you say you'll do—know your limitations, manage your priorities and deliver on your promises.
- Accountability: Own your mistakes, apologize, and make amends.
- Vault: Don't share things that aren't yours to share, e.g. confidential or sensitive information about others.

KEY QUOTES

"The ultimate goal in receiving feedback is a skillful blend of listening, integrating feedback, and reflecting it back with accountability."

"Integrity is choosing courage over comfort."

- Integrity: Choose what's right, courageous and aligned with your values, not what's easy, fast or comfortable.
- Nonjudgment: Talk openly and honestly without judgment.
- Generosity: Give others the benefit of the doubt. Interpret their intentions, words and actions as generously as possible.



How to use the BRAVING Inventory:

- Build/operationalize trust in teams: Get your team members to individually list down 1-2 observable behaviors for each of the 7 elements. Then, discuss the behaviors that you'll commit to and hold one another accountable for. Remember: trust is built over many small moments, and the goal of this exercise is to help you to identify *how* to build trust as a team.
- Develop self-trust: Before you can trust others, you must first learn to trust yourself. Recall a past setback or disappointment and use the inventory to consider your response for each element, e.g. did you set/convey boundaries clearly and keep your promises? Give yourself a pat on the back for each trustworthy behavior, and improve where you fell short.



Skill #4: Learning to Rise



When you learn to sky-dive, the first thing you learn is how to survive a hard landing. Likewise, before you sky-dive into vulnerability, equip yourself with the skills and systems to bounce back from failures.



The Reckoning: Learn to recognize when you're emotionally hooked by something, and get curious about what's going on.

- Recognize the symptoms that you're "hooked", e.g. when you replay a conversation repeatedly in your head, feel intense physical/emotional sensations like knots in your stomach, anxiety, confusion, fear or pain.
- Calm down and get curious about what's truly happening:

KEY QUOTES

"The intention behind the BRAVING Inventory is a tool for creating the time, space, and intention to talk about trust in a way that's productive and actionable."

"We can never overestimate the relationship between self-trust and trusting others."

"We can't expect people to be brave and risk failure if they're not prepped for hard landings."

"The Learning to Rise process is about getting up from our falls, overcoming our mistakes, and facing hurt in a way that brings more wisdom and wholeheartedness into our lives."

- (i) Slow down. Breathe deeply, counting to 4 for each inhale/ exhale.
- (ii) Ask yourself if you have enough information to freak out, and if freaking out will help you in any way. Use phrases like: "The story I'm telling myself is...", "I make up that...."
- (iii) Give yourself a permission slip to feel. Don't default to defensive behaviors, e.g. lashing out at others, suppressing or stockpiling the hurt.



The Rumble. In the absence of data, we tend to make up stories. Our "shitty first draft" (SFD) is typically full of imaginary fears.

- Take control of your SFD. Write down your response, including your emotions, bodily reactions, thoughts, beliefs, and actions.
- Do a reality check. Consider:
 - (i) What you must learn about the *situation*, including the facts you have/lack and the assumptions you're making;
 - (ii) What you must learn about the other *people* involved; and
 - (iii) What you must learn about *yourself*, including the role you played and the underlying reasons for your response.
- When you see the gap between your stories and facts, you can start to take control of your stories instead of allowing them to control you.
- To rumble as a team, first get everyone to write down their thoughts and feelings to make the SFDs explicit. Then, define what you need to rumble about, the additional data needed, and the key lessons you've learned.



The Revolution. Ultimately, the only success that matters is what brings meaning and joy to *you*. Brown urges each of us to answer the call to courage, and support others to do the same. As the collective courage in an organization increases, so will its chances for success.

KEY QUOTES

"If the reckoning is how we walk into a tough story, the rumble is where we go to the mat with it and own it."

"Writing slows the winds and calms the seas."

"Own the story and you get to write the ending. Deny the story and it owns you."

"Make your joy and meaning list and make sure that you use it as you define success for yourself."